STILL ON A PLATEAU

The drop in PM Modi's ratings has not translated into a corresponding boost for the Congress and the Opposition. The anti-incumbency space seems more open

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PTI

The Opposition in India has far more political room today than it did six months ago. What is not clear is who will benefit from the drop in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's ratings. In the August 2026 edition of the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey, Modi's score on the preferred-prime-minister question saw an almost six-point dive, from 54.7 per cent in January to 48.7 per cent now. Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, however, has barely moved, from 26.6 per cent to 27.1 per cent. The gap between them has narrowed, but largely because Modi has lost support. For the Congress, this is the uncomfortable part of the MOTN findings.

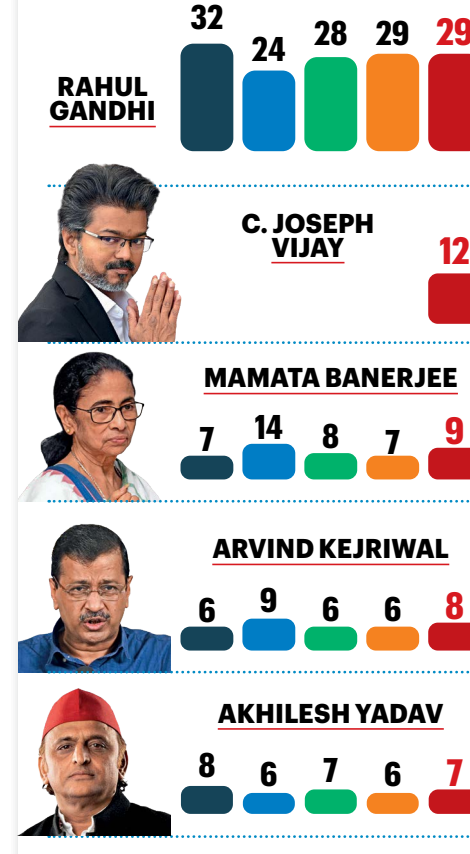
Yet, Rahul remains the Opposition's most acceptable national face. Asked who should lead an Opposition alliance, 29 per cent chose him, almost exactly where he was in January (28.6 per cent). But look at who comes in second. Kollywood superstar and Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay, with no previous track record, debuts at 12.2 per cent, well ahead of veterans such as Trinamool's Mamata Banerjee, Arvind Kejriwal (Aam Aadmi Party) and Akhilesh Yadav (Samajwadi party). In the PM question too, Vijay gets 9.2 per cent, second only to Rahul among Opposition figures.

Vijay's arrival is therefore more than a curiosity. A new face is attracting more acceptance than leaders who have spent years building parties, governments and national profiles. It would be premature to treat this as transferable electoral strength, but it certainly points to an appetite for a fresh Opposition face.

The contrast with Mamata and Kejriwal is striking, especially since political and electoral setbacks have diminished their national heft. In February 2024, Mamata had 16.5 per cent support as the best Opposition alliance leader; Kejriwal had 17.4 per cent. They are now at 8.5 and 7.5, respectively. Yet their decline has not produced a corresponding boom for Rahul. The Opposition space remains fragmented, no one is dominant.

Rahul's personal performance numbers are better than his leadership preference numbers. As LoP in the Lok Sabha, 48.2 per cent now rate him 'outstanding' or 'good', up from 44 per cent in January, while the combined 'poor/very poor' rating fell from

Q. Who among the current Opposition leaders is best suited to lead the Opposition alliance?



Rahul retains top slot, debutant Vijay edges past veteran leaders

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say